Discourses of "Herbivore Masculinity" in Japanese Love Advice Books

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Abstract

In the last decade, discourses of non-conforming masculinities have become increasingly prominent in Japanese mass media. In particular, the so-called "herbivore men" have been made infamous by Japanese newspapers and were accused of being responsible for sinking birth rates and economic stagnation in Japan (Schad-Seifert 2016). In this article, I explore the discourse on the "herbivore men" in Japanese love advice books which are meant to guide and inform the (female) reader's assessment of potential romantic partners. Utilising Siegfried Jäger's methodological approach (2015), this discursive analysis focuses on the line of discourse that implicitly criticises the "herbivore men" and rejects their turn away from hegemonic images of masculinity. The analysis yields that the "herbivore man" is constructed as an 'unnatural' form of masculinity in these publications, which allegedly causes women to become sexually active and career-driven "carnivores." Japanese women's empowerment from hegemonic gender ideals is thereby misrepresented as a symptom of psychological distress due to changing masculinities. By perpetuating ideas of biological determinism linked to the backlash against the "gender-free" movement in the early 2000s, this line of discourse propagates problematic relations of gender and power in Japanese society.

Keywords: Japan, masculinity, gender, backlash, advice, self-help, herbivore men, carnivore women, gender-free.

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Introduction

The breakdown of the bubble economy in Japan in the early 1990s was followed by a period of stagnant economic growth commonly referred to as "the lost two decades" (Nakamura 2017: 1). Rising unemployment rates, a collective feeling of insecurity, as well as social and cultural uprooting accompanied the economic recession (Dasgupta 2009: 79-80). The prolonged financial crisis destabilised established heteronormative practices such as the post-war model of marriage, stay-at home motherhood, as well as the idealised way of life of the hard-working Japanese salaryman (Nast 2016: 1). Consequently, "the lost two decades" set up a process of redefinition of heterosexual male identity that resulted in "the emergence and to some degree social legitimation of alternate discourses of masculinity" in Japan (Charlesbois 2017: 167).

Masculinities that diverge from the hegemonic ideal have been discussed in Japanese mass media since the 1980s. Over the course of the last ten years, however, these gender discourses have been amplified: "new types of men" have been given catchy labels, such as the so-called *bentō danshi* 弁当男子, men who cook their own boxed lunch (Yuen 2014); *ikumen* イクメン, men who actively contribute to child rearing (Mizukoshi et al. 2015); or *suītsu danshi* スイーツ男子, men who prefer sweet drinks and desserts to spicy food and beer (Holtzman 2018). One of the most widely discussed "new" masculinities in the Japanese public discourse is that of the so-called "herbivore man" (*sōshokukei danshi* 草食系男子). The term refers to heterosexual men who display a rather docile or passive approach towards dating when compared to the "carnivore men" (*nikushokukei danshi* 肉食系男子) who actively "hunt" women akin to predators hunting their prey (Saladin 2015: 56-57). "Herbivore men" have been portrayed as disinterested in romantic relationships and sexual intimacy, and to have certain traits that are marked as feminine such as an interest in beauty products (Saladin 2015; Schad-Seifert 2016).

A backlash[1] marked the Japanese mass media's reaction to the emergence of "herbivore masculinity"—a counterstrike to suppress any form of subversive gender performance or feminist discourse. Japanese newspapers and television programmes reported on this masculinity, but it was also extensively thematised in a broad range of different media formats, including love advice books for women. Love advice books not only supply the reader with guidelines on how to perform gender but also on how to assess other people's gender performance in interpersonal interactions, including

[1] The term "backlash," coined by Susan Faludi in her book *Backlash: The Undeclared War against Women* (1991), was imbibed by Japanese feminists to describe the counter attacks against feminists by conservative forces in Japan (Yamaguchi 2014: 541). The most prominent backlash followed the mainstreaming of feminism in Japan after the introduction of the Basic Law for a Gender Equal Society in 1999 (Kano 2011: 41).

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romantic relationships, dating, as well as sexual relations. As a popular form of mass entertainment, advice books provide valuable insight into the development of masculinity discourses or ideas about what constitutes a "man," which are debated in society (Knudson 2014: 116).

In this article, I explore the discourse on "herbivore men" in Japanese love advice books in order to gain deeper insight into the discursive mechanisms of the perpetuation of gender norms. A detailed analysis of Sakuragi Piroko's 桜木ピロコ book, *Lessons in Love for Carnivore Women: How Do They Devour the Herbivore Men?* (*Nikushokukei joshi no ren'aigaku: kanojo tachi wa ika ni sōshokukei danshi o kuimakuru no ka* 肉食系女子の恋愛学: 彼女たちはいかに草食系男子を食いまくるのか) (2009), enables focused attention on the discourses that align with the backlash against "herbivore men" in the mass media.

Theoretical Framework: Masculinity in the Japanese Cultural Context

Research in gender studies defines masculinity as a gendered construct that is formed by sociocultural, economic, and political conditions within a society (Dasgupta 2013: 7). Gender is not determined by biological factors or the body but is a social practice that has developed through a historic process (Connell 2005: 1625). Based on feminist ideas of gender construction, research on masculinities aims to challenge the established notions of how to be male instead of accepting it as a given (Koch and Steger 2013: 12).

The concept of hegemonic masculinity by the Australian sociologist Raewyn Connell offers a fundamental theoretical framework for the comprehension of gender and power relations within a patriarchal society (Connell 2005: 2015). Based on Antonio Gramsci's definition of hegemony, the term does not necessarily indicate the most wide-spread form of masculinity but rather describes the ideologically ruling form of a certain time and cultural space (Connell 2015: 77). This hegemony is retained not only by force but mainly by the construction and representation of ideal images of masculinity such as sports stars or action heroes in movies (Connell and Messerschmidt 2005: 846). Consequently, hegemonic masculinity has a normative function by representing an image of what a successful, desirable, and "proper" man is supposed to be like in societal discourse (Connell 2015: 77). Other non-conforming or oppositional types of masculinity—such as gay masculinities, as well as all forms of femininity and other non-binary forms of gender—are subordinated to the hegemonic form and thereby disadvantaged in society (Connell 2015; Connell and Messerschmidt 2005). It is important to recognise that the power structures of gender/sexuality intersect with other structural factors within a society's discourse, such as class, ethnicity/race, ability/disability, mobility/immobility etc. (Grzanka 2018; Connell

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2015; Hanson 2010). These factors overlap and thereby shape the individual's experience of social injustice (Grzanka 2018: 15).

Research in Japanese Studies pinpoints the archetype of the salaryman (*sararīman* サラリーマン) as the hegemonic masculinity of the post-war and bubble periods in Japan (Charlesbois 2017; Dasgupta 2013; Hidaka 2010; Roberson and Suzuki 2003: 1). During the time of Japan's "economic miracle" from the 1960s–1980s, the salaryman—a hard-working, white-collar employee—came to be associated with the nation's ascendancy as an economic powerhouse (Dasgupta 2013: 9). Salarymen were even called "corporate warriors" (*kigyō senshi* 企業戦士) as they "were expected to sacrifice their time, autonomy, family life, and even health" like soldiers (Charlesbois 2017: 166).

The ideology of heterosexual complementarity, which ascribes separate areas of responsibility to men and women within a relationship and, by extension, within Japanese society, is the core of this hegemonic masculinity (Hidaka 2010: 2). While masculinity is linked to the public sphere (labour), femininity is associated with the private sphere (household and child rearing) (Dasgupta 2013: 9). Within this ideological framework, men's *ikigai* 生きがい (something that endows life with meaning) is work (Mathews 2003: 110). Therefore, men are expected to work hard and be loyal to their companies to support the Japanese economy (Hidaka 2010: 3). Even though women have always been a part of the Japanese workforce, men are seen as the embodiment of paid labour (Dasgupta 2000: 192). In order to maintain the salaryman lifestyle, which is linked to long working hours and social work events, their wives are expected to take care of the household and child rearing (Charlesbois 2016: 5; Hidaka 2010: 3). The idealised form of femininity, or emphasised femininity (Connell and Messerschmidt 2015) that developed as a counterpart to the hegemonic masculinity of the salaryman, is personified by the supportive full-time house wife (*sengyō shufu* 専業主婦) in Japan (Charlesbois 2017; Dasgupta 2013). Like hegemonic masculinity, emphasised femininity is not the most common performance of the female gender in Japan,[2] but consists of a set of ideas about how a woman should be. It thus has a normative function and thereby sustains the gender hegemony (Connell 2015; Messerschmidt 2011).

Following the burst of the bubble economy, the recession and ongoing globalisation process stripped away certain aspects of the idealised salaryman lifestyle, such as lifelong employment in the white-collar sector and financial security (Dasgupta 2013: 9). However, the notion of the heterosexual complementarity of men and women remains intact today (Dasgupta 2013: 9). The societal structure based on a gender division of labour leaves women with a significant disadvantage as participants in the

[2] The subversion of patriarchal ideals of femininity by Japanese women has drawn considerable attention in gender and queer studies (e.g. Fanasca 2019; Charlesbois 2014; Kinsella 2014; Maree 2007).

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Japanese workforce (Mathews 2003: 109). Japan's gender wage gap[3] has proven to be larger than that of other developed countries (Onozuka 2016: 54). Since the household and childcare are still considered the woman's main responsibility, women often only work part time or take on temporary employment (Charlesbois 2017: 166). Japanese men are not strongly invested in sharing the domestic workload (Mizukoshi et al. 2015: 3); women are thus often left juggling jobs, childcare, and household duties after marriage (Kawano 2014: 49). This distribution of tasks in wedlock takes a toll on women's careers and leaves them dependent on their husbands, which can lead to dire financial situations in case of a divorce.

Moreover, this relationship model is also detrimental to men whose lives are strongly controlled and regulated by their jobs (Mathews 2003: 109). It still holds true today that Japanese masculinity is strongly defined by work and the ability to provide for the family, rather than playing an active role as a father (Mizukoshi et al. 2015: 3). The difficulty of finding permanent white-collar work in the 1990s seems to have emphasised the importance of stable employment as the base of hegemonic masculinity (Dasgupta 2013: 82). Freeters (*furītā* フリーター), non-permanent contract workers, for example, were found to have problems finding marriage partners because they are not able to fulfil the rigid expectations of a husband and father (Dasgupta 2013: 82). Even though men have had the right to take parental leave since the Childcare Leave Law (*Ikuji kyūgyō hō* 育児休業法) was established in 1992 (Charlesbois 2014: 7), it is still almost impossible for them to invoke this right due to demanding and inflexible conditions in the Japanese workplace environment (Ishii Kuntz 2013: 268).

On the interpersonal level, it is an important part of the hegemonic concept of masculinity that men should take the leading position (*rīdā/rīdō* リーダー・リードー) in a heterosexual partnership—i.e. ask women out on dates, propose marriage, and initiate sexual encounters (Itō et al. 2011: 6). Men are usually expected to pay the bill for dinner and to cover other expenses for their date or partner (Itō et al. 2011: 6). Desirable behaviour for men includes being physically and mentally strong or tough, taking on hard physical work, and not showing emotions such as anger or sadness (Itō et al. 2011: 6).

On the other hand, women are expected to be passive (*judōteki* 受動的) in their behaviour, which means it is not deemed appropriate to invite men on dates or to speak about sexual experiences (Itō et al. 2011: 11). If women or men do not conform to these ideal gender constructions, they might be subject to harassment or shame by

[3] The term "gender wage gap" refers to "the difference between median earnings of men and women relative to median earnings of men" (OECD 2019). According to the OECD, Japan's gender wage gap was 24.6 per cent in 2016, while countries like the United States (18.14 per cent), Germany (15.51 per cent) or Australia (14.29 per cent) had a significantly smaller gender wage gap in the same year (OECD 2019). Japan is only surpassed by Korea, which had a gender wage gap of 36.67 per cent in 2016 (OECD 2019).

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being marked with terms of abuse such as "slut" (*yariman* ヤリマン) for women or "faggot" (*okama* オカマ) for men (cf. Connell 2015: 132). This construction of men as leading and women as passive within a romantic or sexual relationship can be considered a part of the ideology of complementary heterosexuality that is further connected to hegemonic masculinity. However, it is important to note that there is a clear distinction between gender ideology and lived reality which will be further demonstrated below. Evidently, this reductive scope of the gender binary does not represent the lived diversity in gender expression and sexuality in Japanese society (Itō et al. 2011: 11). Since everyone—not only women and gender non-conforming members of society but also men—suffers from this gender dichotomy, the Japanese sociologist Itō Kimio[4] 伊藤公雄 proposes that men should find their own identity or *jibunrashisa* 自分らしさ instead of conforming to stereotypical masculinity (*danseirashisa* 男性らしさ) (Kumata 2005: 4).

Literature Discussion: The Discourse on "Herbivore Men" in Japan in the Late 2000s

Even though the hegemonic masculinity of the salaryman seems resistant to change, the process of societal reorientation set up by the burst of Japan's bubble economy in the 1990s brought forth numerous new masculinities—the "herbivore man" being one of them (Charlesbois 2017: 167). The term *sōshoku danshi* 草食男子 or *sōshokukei danshi* 草食系男子 ("herbivore man" or "herbivore-type man") was coined by the columnist Fukasawa Maki 深澤真紀 in her thirty-two part series on types of male consumers for the online paper *Nikkei Bijinesu Onrain* 日経ビジネスオンライン in 2006 (Schad-Seifert 2016: 268; Noack 2014: 205). According to Fukasawa, "herbivore men" are sexually more passive than previous generations (Fukasawa 2006 in Saladin 2017: 20). Because women are now also initiating sexual contact, Fukasawa claims that traditional gender roles have become obsolete (Fukasawa 2006 in Saladin 2017: 20). "Herbivore men" are further described as feminine or "girly" consumers as they are said to have a preference for skincare products, fashion, sweet desserts, and fine-dining (Chen 2012: 283).

The presumed femininity of "herbivore men" is mirrored in the masculinity of "carnivore women" (*nikushokukei joshi* 肉食系女子). This term was also coined by

[4] Itō Kimio is seen as the founding father of men's studies in Japan which had its beginnings in the Japanese women's liberation movement (*ūmanribu* ウーマンリブ) in the 1980s (Kumata 2005: 3). Itō examines the change in concepts of masculinity from the postwar era to the present day and contributed a great deal to standard literature in Japanese gender studies and sociology (see Itō et al. 2011). The deconstruction of men's societal role as breadwinners (*daikokubashira* 大黒柱) and women's role as the household manager is the aim of Itō's work (Kumata 2005: 4).

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Fukasawa (Schad-Seifert 2016: 268; Fukasawa 2009: 11) but later picked up by other authors of non-fiction books (e.g. Sakuragi 2009). Young Japanese women are said to have become "carnivores" who actively approach sexual partners and hunt careers (Schad-Seifert 2016: 268). They therefore do not conform to the ideal "emphasised femininity" of the housewife who strongly values marriage and motherhood.

In addition to her column, Fukasawa published a book about different types of male consumers in the Heisei era, including the "herbivore men" (Fukasawa 2009). A special issue of the Japanese women's magazine *Non-no* ノンノ published in April 2008 was edited by Fukasawa and fully dedicated to the "herbivore men" (Matsuoka 2012: 27). Subsequently, the term started to gain momentum in public discourse. While Japanese mass media reported on the "herbivore men," non-fiction books, including love advice books, as well as Japanese comics, novels, TV series and even a movie were dedicated to this new type of masculinity (Luschmann 2018: 30). Due to the increasing popularity of the term, Fukasawa was awarded the U-can prize for the ten trend words of the year (*Yūkyan shingo ryūkōgo taishō* ユーキャン新語流行語大賞) by the renowned publishing company Jiyū Kokuminsha 自由国民社 (Noack 2014: 205; Schad-Seifert 2016: 267). This award led to further distribution of the term and, in due course, the general population gained broader awareness of "herbivore men" (Schad-Seifert 2016: 267).

Following these events in the media, several surveys were published that showed a high identification rate of younger men with the term "herbivore man" in comparison to older generations (Fotache 2016: 184; Schad-Seifert 2016: 272). This was interpreted as a generational change in male behaviour, even though the numbers given in these studies might not be representative due to the ambiguity of the definition of the term (Fotache 2016: 184).

"Herbivore men" received considerable attention after these media events, resulting in a discourse climax in 2009. This is also reflected in the publication of quite a large number of non-fiction books that will be further elaborated upon below. However, these events also stirred up conservative forces within Japanese mass media and resulted in a gender backlash. "Herbivore men" were blamed by the mass media for Japan's declining birth rate due to their alleged sexual passiveness and reluctance to get married (Koch and Steger 2013: 4). Furthermore, they are said to lack career ambition which is seen as a threat to the future of Japan's economy (Schad-Seifert 2016: 274). Schad-Seifert observed the discourse about this new masculinity in the Japanese mass media, in particular the *Asashi Shinbun* 朝日新聞, concluding that the construction of the "herbivore man" as a "deviant or losing masculinity" shows a societal practice of reaffirmation of established masculinity norms (Schad-Seifert 2016: 275). Additionally, Kanda's analysis of the discourse in personal blogs showed an increase in negative opinions and a decrease in affirmative opinions about "herbivore men" between 2008 and 2011 (Kanda 2011). This outcome reflects the general development

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of the public discourse in reaction to the backlash against the "herbivore men" in the mass media.

The attention the "herbivore men" received from the mass media also led some Japanese researchers to test whether these accusations were true. Suzuki (2010) published a quantitative study about the changes in attachment behaviour of young Japanese people in 2010. Based on annual surveys about Japanese attachment behaviour by TBS television, Suzuki found a general trend of Japanese people between thirteen and fifty-nine becoming increasingly "herbivorous." In other words, from 1980–2009, Japanese men and women became more passive regarding the pursuit of romantic partnerships (Suzuki 2010: 169). In a similar study about the behaviour of university students, Hidaka et al. (2015: 1) could not find a trend indicating the increased passiveness of men and increased activeness of women in the pursuit of relationships. Both studies debunked the media narrative of men losing interest in sexual relationships with women, and women being 'overly' sexually active—a myth that is based on a sexist worldview.

In reaction to the backlash against the "herbivore men," Fukasawa Maki, the creator of the term, later claimed in her column that she had intended to praise the "herbivore men" as men who see their partners as equals and value their families and hometowns, instead of pointing out that they are "weak men" (Fukasawa 2015). The "herbivore men's" refusal to conform to the salaryman lifestyle can rather be interpreted as a form of opposition to the hegemonic ideal of the man as the breadwinner (Charlesbois 2013: 96; Koch and Steger 2013: 14-15). On the other hand, there have been doubts about the generation of "herbivore men" showing a true change in Japanese ideas of masculinity. Chen claims that the herbivore's interest in fashion and skincare comes from men catering to their female love interests—not from a substantial change of masculinity ideals (2012: 304). In his recent article, Charlesbois (2017: 177) proposes that not all forms of "herbivore masculinity" are geared towards gender equality, but that the concept also contains toxic forms of masculinity promoting narcissistic self-optimisation and hedonistic consumerism. He therefore proposes distinguishing "equality masculinities" from "non-equality masculinities" (Charlesbois 2017: 179). Saladin (2015) also warns against pre-emptively concluding that this generation of men is reformed and no longer constrained by gender stereotypes. He suggests that new or different aspects of masculinity have just been included or combined with older aspects of hegemonic masculinity but have not replaced them (Saladin 2015: 68).

In addition, it is important to mention that the "herbivore masculinity" is a Japanese heterosexual, white-collar, able-bodied masculinity and is therefore still on the privileged end of the spectrum of masculinities within Japanese society. Nevertheless, the emergence of new heterosexual masculinities that challenge the hegemonic masculinity of the salaryman and pluralise notions of masculinity is important in moving towards the establishment of a society based on gender equality.

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Locating Discursive Fields in Non-Fiction: A Brief Overview of Discursive Structures

Adapting Siegfried Jäger's practical methodology for critical discourse analysis (2015) for use with monographs, I conducted an analysis of the structure of the discourse on "herbivore men" in non-fiction books. This step served two purposes: first, to get an overview of the discourse; and second, to collect a sample for detailed analysis. I conducted empirical archive work in the National Diet Library in Japan in June 2017 where I openly approached the available body of text to find discursive patterns and structures within the discourse.

At the National Diet Library, all available publications found using the keywords *sōshokukei danshi* (herbivore-type man) and *sōshoku danshi* 草食男子 (herbivore man) were examined. I thereby focused on publications that really engaged with this type of masculinity as the main topic, and did not just mention "herbivore man" as a buzzword. The body of publications that I inspected consisted mainly of articles in various Japanese magazines, such as lifestyle magazines, but also research bulletins and journals. However, by focusing on Japanese non-fiction books, an increase in publications released from 2008–2010 on the topic of the "herbivore man" was found. It can be assumed that this increase is due to the Japanese public's growing awareness of this type of masculinity during this timeframe[5] following Fukasawa's publications and the mass media picking up the term.

The larger discourse on "herbivore men" in Japanese non-fiction books includes DIY-handbooks (*manyuaru* マニュアル); self-help or self-improvement books (*jikokeihatsusho* 自己啓発書), which discuss the "herbivore man" as a societal phenomenon in general; as well as love advice books for women and men. Charlesbois divides the general discourse on "herbivore men" into three thematic fields: the approach to work life; interpersonal relationships; and consumer behaviour, including aesthetical practices of "herbivore men" (Charlesbois 2017). Even though within these three thematic fields, specific topics are addressed, they are not isolated spaces of discourse, but rather flow into and through each other. Therefore, these fields are often discussed in relation to each other; for example, books about interpersonal relationships also take up topical elements from the discourse on consumer behaviour and vice versa.

Non-fiction books that thematise the work life and career of "herbivore men" are mainly self-improvement books which aim to help "herbivore men" develop strategies in order to be more successful in the workplace, reduce stress, and view their own sensitivity as an asset (Luschmann 2018: 35-36). One example of a publication in this

[5] The author and academic Morioka Masahiro 森岡正博, whose love advice book for women is analysed in this article, also reported a heightened awareness and engagement with "herbivore men" in the public discourse in Japan around 2008 (Morioka 2013: 3).

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thematic context is Okuda Hiromi's 奥田弘美 *Sōshokukei bijinesuman no tame no sutoresufurī shigotojutsu* 草食系ビジネスマンのためのストレスフリー仕事術 (Stress Free Life Hacks for Herbivorous Businessmen) (2009). By learning twenty-four "hacks" or techniques, "herbivore men" are said to be able to turn their gentleness into a "weapon" (Amazon Japan 2018b).

In comparison to the first category, the non-fiction books that deal with the consumer behaviour of "herbivore men" are more analytical and often describe this masculinity as a present societal phenomenon and a product of the lost decades (see, e.g., Schad-Seifert 2016). This line of discourse heavily influenced and shaped the image of the "herbivore man" in Japanese society. One example is Fukasawa's book, *An Illustrated Encyclopaedia of Men in the Heisei Era* (平成男子図鑑 *Heisei danshi zukan*) (2007), which was based on her aforementioned column, and was reissued in 2009 with the subtitle *Generation of Herbivore Men* (草食男子世代 *Sōshokukei danshi sedai*) (Fukasawa 2009; Noack 2014: 205). Furthermore, the well-known marketing and consumer behaviour author Ushikubo Megumi 牛窪恵 published several books in this thematic category—some of them have been heavily referenced in Western and Japanese academic discourse (e.g. Ushikubo 2008).

This article aims to shed light on the line of discourse that focuses mainly on the interpersonal relationships of "herbivore men" in love advice books. Even though the focal point of these books is mainly the romantic relationships of "herbivore men," other parts of their social lives such as friendships, workplace connections with colleagues, or these men's bonds with their parents are also discussed. These books either target "herbivore men" themselves, women who want to or already lead a romantic relationship with a "herbivore man," or both of these groups simultaneously. Since these books try to provide advice to the reader, they also include interactive elements such as personality tests through which the reader can identify whether someone is a "herbivore type," or what subcategory of "herbivore" they or their partner belong to. This line of discourse is discussed in detail below.

Structural Analysis: The Discourse on the Interpersonal Relationships of "Herbivore Men" in Japanese Love Advice Books

Eight love advice books published from 2008–2010 form part of the line of discourse about interpersonal relationships of "herbivore men;" six were published in 2009. As previously mentioned, the climax of the discourse occurred in 2009, reflected by the number of publications of love advice books that year. Four of these publications take on affirmative positions, supporting the masculinity of the "herbivore man," while two books represent positions that reject this masculinity and support the gender backlash in the mass media. Overall, the discourse in love advice books shows a broad spectrum of positions which range from affirmative/progressive to

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hostile/conservative. The closer the author is located to the academic discourse in Japan, the more progressive their publications tend to be in relation to the acceptance of alternative discourses of masculinity. On the other hand, the more a publication reinforces gender stereotypes, the more it can be located within the entertainment discourse.[6]

The affirmative line of discourse in Japanese love advice books can be considered a counter-discourse to the gender backlash discourse of the mass media. The idea that "herbivore men" are better partners than older generations of men is prevalent in these publications. Qualities that are perceived as feminine—such as their interest in skincare, fashion, and fine dining—are seen as meritorious due to their ability to share these interests with their (female) partners. Infidelity is said to be unthinkable for "herbivore men" since they are not interested in casual sexual encounters but rather value stable long-term relationships and emotional connections (Luschmann 2018: 114). Because of their non-aggressiveness, it is implied that violence against women or predatory behaviour are not part of "herbivore" men's nature (ibid). Because of their passive constitution, they also do not "pick up women" but interact with them on a platonic basis. This requires women to be more assertive if they are interested in "herbivore men" (Luschmann 2018). Instead of focusing mainly on their career and their work relationships, "herbivore men" are said to invest more of their energy in a harmonious family life and friendships (ibid: 114). Due to this domestic focus, "herbivore men" are believed to be more active in taking on domestic chores and child rearing than the men of the bubble generation (ibid). Finding a comfortable work-life-balance is therefore regarded as more important for these men than financial gain (ibid).

One example of the affirmative line of discourse in love advice books from 2009 is Morioka Masahiro's 森岡正博 book *Saigo no koi wa sōshokukei danshi ga motte kuru* 最後の恋は草食系男子が持ってくる (Herbivore Men Will Bring Your Last Love) (2009). Coming from an academic background in philosophy and ethics, gender studies, as well as sociology (Morioka 2018a), Morioka's approach to a love advice book can be considered a form of public engagement. What makes this publication stand out within the typical line of discourse is that Morioka appears to have a personal

[6] In the thesis predating this article, the following three samples that are representative of different positions within this line of discourse in 2009 were analysed in greater detail (Luschmann 2018): Morioka Masahiro's 森岡正博 *Saigo no koi wa sōshokukei danshi ga motte kuru* 最後の恋は草食系男子が持ってくる (Herbivore Men Will Bring Your Last Love) (2009), Ushikubo Megumi's 牛窪恵 *Sōshokukei danshi no toriatsukai setsumeisho: torisetsu* 草食系男子の取扱説明書:トリセツ (The User Manual for Herbivore Men) (2009), and Sakuragi Piroko's 桜木ピロコ *Nikushokukei joshi no ren'aigaku: kanojo tachi wa ika ni sōshokukei danshi o kuimakuru no ka* 肉食系女子の恋愛学 : 彼女たちはいかに草食系男子を食いまくるのか (Lessons in Love for Carnivore Women: How Do They Devour the Herbivore Men?) (2009).

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connection to this masculinity and therefore strongly empathises with the "herbivore men." In several accounts, Morioka explains that in his younger years he was also an inexperienced "herbivore man," but then learned how to behave like a "carnivore" in order to be able to approach women (Morioka 2008; 2009). Constructing the "herbivore man" as a new type of masculinity brought on by a generation that did not experience the gruesomeness of war, Morioka sees the new softness of men as a positive consequence of peace in Japan (Morioka 2009: 55). The "herbivore men's" perceived non-aggressiveness is seen as a positive development that might affect the issue of domestic violence (Morioka 2009). Despite Morioka's efforts to support non-hegemonic gender performance in men, he has been criticised by Japanese feminists for being overly enthusiastic about the "herbivore" men's influence on rigid gender relations and the reduction of violence against women in Japan (Morioka 2011). Morioka sees the appearance of the "herbivore men" in public discourse as a sign of a radical change in the perceptions of gender in Japanese society (Morioka 2011: 13). He thereby overlooks the fact that conservative forces are still working to preserve the gender binary, and he thus loses focus on problems that still persist in connection with societal structures of gender and power. Nevertheless, his strategy of supporting heterosexual men's deviation from the hegemonic ideal can be considered beneficial for the legitimisation of alternative heterosexual masculinities.

Positions that reject the masculinity of the "herbivore man" are in the minority (two out of six love advice books) in the examined line of discourse in 2009. Both publications were written by Sakuragi Piroko; this position therefore constitutes an exception within this line of discourse. However, if put in the context of the larger discourse on "herbivore men" in the mass media, Sakuragi's position proves to be part of the gender backlash in Japan. Therefore, *Lessons in Love for Carnivore Women: How Do They Devour The Herbivore Men?* (2009) was chosen for a detailed analysis in this article in order to investigate how the gender backlash is also perpetuated in love advice books.

Detailed Analysis: Sakuragi Piroko's *Lessons in Love for Carnivore Women: How Do They Devour the Herbivore Men?*

In order to gain deeper insights into the discursive production of knowledge about the new "herbivore" form of masculinity, a detailed analysis consisting of five steps was conducted. First, the "institutional context" of the discursive fragment was investigated; the publication's discursive level was located and the author's embeddedness in different societal discourses was explored by examining the author's publishing history and background (Jäger 2015: 99-100). Second, the structure and contents of the text was analysed in order to trace the lines of argument and their intersections with other discourses (ibid: 102). Through close reading and annotating topics that

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were woven into the text, the logic and structure of the arguments were reviewed. Third, the use of language in constructing the "herbivore man" was examined. Following a Foucauldian approach to discourse, the language analysis is not meant to contribute to linguistics, but rather serves to find "routines in language" that (re)produce meaning within a certain line of discourse (ibid: 103). These "routines in language" can be found in the form of patterns in the narration, proverbs or sayings (ibid: 103; Link 1982). Based on the outcomes of the previous steps and repeated close reading, "perceptions of normalcy and truth" presented in this discursive fragment were extracted that reveal the ideological bias and agenda behind the publication (ibid: 108). Lastly, the results of the detailed analysis were reflected on vis-à-vis the mass media discourse in order to conclude the analysis. The outcomes of the detailed analysis are discussed below.

Discursive Level and Institutional Context

The institutional context of this discursive fragment is strongly defined by Sakuragi's involvement in the Japanese entertainment industry. In the author's notes on the book cover, Sakuragi calls herself a *moteraitā* モテライター, an author who wants to provide her audience with advice on how to become popular (2009). In addition, Sakurai claims to specialise in humoristic love advice and calls herself a comedy writer (*owarai raitā* お笑いライター) in her personal blog (Sakuragi 2018b). In 2018, Amazon Japan offered thirteen books by Sakuragi that were all dedicated to the topics of love and sexuality in an entertainment context (Amazon Japan 2018a). In general, Sakuragi's publications target men as well as women; they aim to offer solutions to dating problems and strategies to find a partner (Luschmann 2010: 88-89).

Besides being an author of popular non-fiction, Sakuragi is also known for her appearances on Japanese television. On her Twitter profile, Sakuragi explains that she had previously appeared on TV shows by NHK (Japan Broadcasting Corporation) or *Terebi Tōkyō* テレビ東京 (TV Tōkyō) (Sakuragi 2018c). Besides being a minor celebrity on Japanese television and a popular writer of Japanese love advice books, Sakuragi self-identifies as a "carnivore woman" on her personal blog (Ameba 2018a). Sakuragi thereby implies she is personally involved in the topical issue of changing gender relations in Japan. Additionally, she declares that she attended over 2,000 dating events (*gōkon* 合コン) and talked to 10,000 women in order to comprehend why women became "carnivorous" and men became "herbivorous" for the love advice book under analysis (2009: 2). Sakuragi also references other participants in the "herbivore man" discourse such as Fukasawa Maki and Morioka Masahiro in this publication (2009).

Sakuragi's love advice book (2009) can be located in the entertainment genre. The publication mainly targets women but tries to reach a male audience simultaneously. According to the author's notes in a different publication, this book was translated and

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published in several other Asian countries in 2010 because of its popularity (Sakuragi 2010).

Discursive Patterns in Argumentation and Routines in Language

The idea of an allegedly 'natural' binary, reactive connectedness, and hierarchy between masculinity and femininity—one reversed by the emergence of the "herbivore men"—is the centre of Sakuragi's argument. The author crudely calls this the "phenomenon of reversion of dick and pussy" (*chinko to manko no gyakuten genshō* チンコとマンコの逆転現象) (2009: 16). One example of her perception of 'natural' gender is the following quote in which she argues that the definition of masculinity and femininity is apparent in the shape and form of the genitals:

> In love and sex, amongst other things, men are active, women are passive. This form has been the norm at any time, in any [part of the] world. Biologically speaking this is also the intended appearance. If you think about the shape of penis and vagina you can easily understand this (Sakuragi 2009: 16).

This quote reflects the aspect of hegemonic masculinity which requires men to "lead" or to play the active part in a sexual relationship, while women are expected to be receptive or passive as described by Itō et al. (2011). In this publication, "herbivore men" are perceived as a new generation of men who have become more passive/feminine in their pursuit of sexual and romantic partners, as well as careers, which has purportedly led women to become more active/masculine in these aspects. "Herbivore masculinity" is thereby constructed in opposition to "carnivore femininity" within the gender binary. In the following section, I will look at the construction of the carnivore woman and the herbivore man in Sakuragi's text in greater detail in order to unveil its intrinsic biological determinism and the perpetuation of stereotypical discourses of gender.

The Construction of the "Herbivore Man"

Despite the categorisation of different types of "herbivore men," several traits are attributed to all of them in this discursive fragment. In general, Sakuragi describes "herbivore men" as passive (*shōkyokuteki* 消極的), timid, gullible, childish and "too honest" (*baka shōjiki* バカ正直) (Sakuragi 2009: 28). For this reason, women are said to take advantage of their naiveté and 'use' them for casual sex and as "slaves" (*dorei* 奴隷) in BDSM[7] practices (ibid: 53) yet not engage in serious relationships with them

[7] BDSM is an abbreviation for "Bondage and Discipline, Dominance and Submission, Sadism and Masochism" and describes different practices and modes of behaviour that involve an erotic exchange of power (Carlström 2018: 209).

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(ibid: 41). This is illustrated with anecdotes from the life of "carnivore women" (ibid: 41, 53). In clear contradiction to the short stories about sexually active "herbivore men" that the author gives as examples,[8] these men are portrayed to be sexually inexperienced and to have a low sex drive (ibid: 28). The character description of the "herbivore men" in this publication is someone with no self-esteem, pride, attitude, craving for recognition or fighting spirit (ibid: 28)—features that Sakuragi deems present in a "true" man. "Herbivore men" are further described as unconstricted by gender boundaries[9] (*jendā furī* ジェンダーフリー) (ibid: 82), which is interpreted as a negative feature in this publication. The development of "herbivore masculinity" is said to be caused by Japan's economic recession which is named as the reason men lost the two key factors of their self-esteem: work and money (ibid: 121). This argument positions the "herbivore man" in opposition to the hegemonic masculinity of the salaryman—a symbol of economic prosperity.

Even though economic success is mentioned as a defining factor for "being a man" in this publication (ibid: 121), Sakuragi mainly discusses reproductive and sexual health—an aspect also problematised by the Japanese mass media in relation to "herbivore masculinity." As previously discussed, Japanese newspapers like the *Asahi Shinbun* depicted the "herbivore men" as a new form of masculinity that wreaks havoc on the Japanese population and economy by being "weak" or "unmanly" (Schad-Seifert 2016: 270). Demographic changes like the sinking birth rates in Japan were negatively linked to the sexual passivity of the "herbivore man" in mass media discourse (Schad-Seifert 2016). Sakuragi perpetuates this discourse, as the following quote exemplifies:

> Men have certainly become weak lately. […] Even though they go to dating events, they don't ask for contact details. Playboys have become very rare. […] [Instead] men who only say "It is better to find an emotional connection" and who have no sex drive at all have increased in number. The reason for the sinking birth rate is men's declining libido, chromosomes are said to have become funny etc.; [developments] like these have come to be seen as immense problems (Sakuragi 2009: 1).

In Sakuragi Piroko's love advice book, men of the "herbivore type" are further constructed in comparison with the "carnivore women" by the use of many different anecdotes that describe encounters of these two types. "Herbivore men" are mainly perceived as the "victims" (*gisei* 犠牲) of "carnivore women" (Sakuragi 2009: 116) who are too weak to be able to deal with them. In a section titled "Carnivore Women vs. Herbivore Men," (ibid: 20) Sakuragi describes cases of failed attempts at courtship, romance or sex between heterosexual men and women that she presents as the result of changed or reversed gender performance. Power dynamics in gender relations that

[8] The respective anecdotes are described in greater detail in my M.A. thesis (Luschmann 2018).
[9] This aspect and its connection to the "gender free" discourse is further discussed below.

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diverge from the complementary heterosexuality linked to the hegemonic masculinity are criticised.

One example of the binary construction of gender is the term *gyaku nanpa* 逆ナンパ (reversed picking up) that is mentioned on several occasions in this publication. Sakuragi claims that many men nowadays would wait for women to take the first step in flirting (ibid: 41). She calls this *gyaku nan machi* 逆ナン待ち or "waiting to be reversely picked up" (ibid: 41). "Herbivore men" are said not to be "active" in dating anymore, and therefore women are forced to take on this part (ibid: 46). Sakuragi claims that women would actually prefer men to take the first step because the risk of rejection is higher for women (ibid: 47). She does not explain, however, why the risk of rejection should be lower for men in general. Sakuragi thereby continues the narrative of the reversal of male and female behaviours that springs from assumptions that something like a "natural gender" exists.

Another example is an anecdote titled "The Man Who Cried Because of Reverse Rape" (*Gyaku reipu de gōkyū shita otoko* 逆レイプで号泣した男) (ibid: 23). The anecdote is presented as a humorous story in which a "herbivore man" called B is raped by S-ko, a "carnivore woman" who is senior to him in college (ibid: 23). When B visits S-ko to bring her food while she is unwell in bed, she forces herself on him (ibid: 24). Despite tears running down his face, the "carnivore woman" proceeds to have sex with B (ibid: 24). Because of his unwillingness to participate in the sexual act, the "herbivore man" is ridiculed and the rape is framed as his fault. Implied in this anecdote is the underlying perception that the urge to engage in sexual acts with women is something that is 'natural' and therefore coercion should not be necessary. The author writes that "not being able to suppress one's sexual urges is a feeling that B cannot understand" (ibid: 23).

Like the term *gyaku nanpa* 逆ナンパ (reversed picking up), the term *gyaku reipu* 逆レイプ (reversed rape) implies that a "natural order" to gender exists which has been reversed. This narrative is further based on ideas of biological determinism[10] in which a monocausal link between the biological and the social sphere is established. However, the construct of a "natural masculinity" that is generated in socio-biology is almost entirely fictional (Connell 2015: 97). As Connell further postulates, notions of "natural" or "true masculinity" are usually connected to the male body in discourses of biological determinism (Connell 2005: 1152). The anecdote of "The Man Who Cried Because of Reverse Rape" (Sakuragi 2009: 23) therefore reveals Sakuragi's

[10] The term "biological determinism" refers to the notion of gender being biologically fixed and the perception that a certain way of being male or female is 'natural', which is propagated in socio-biology (Connell 2015: 97). There is a vast body of research dedicated to the deconstruction or subversion of such ideas e.g. Michel Foucault's *The History of Sexuality* (1978) or Judith Butler's *Gender Trouble* (2006).

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perception of the "herbivore men's" body as a "biological machine"[11] that has stopped working as it should.

Besides the aforementioned economic reasons for the development of a "herbivore masculinity," arguments derived from the natural sciences are also used to explain this phenomenon. For example, Sakuragi cites an article written by an Australian researcher in the magazine *Nature* which hypothesises that the Y-chromosome is going to be extinct in five to six million years due to a genetic defect (ibid: 153). Using this article as proof and the "herbivore man" as an example, Sakuragi argues that the male gender is deteriorating because of the defective Y-chromosome (ibid: 153). The masculinity of "herbivore men" is constructed as "unnatural" or "sickly," one that came about by a genetic defect. Sakuragi does not seriously engage with natural sciences and is not able to present any persuasive scientific proof. However, by citing sources that thematise biology and using scientific vocabulary, she gives the false impression that the argument is grounded in the natural sciences.

Similar to the arguments presented by the Japanese mass media, Sakuragi sees proof for the "herbivore men's" alleged dysfunctionality in their lack of pursuit of romance and sexual partners, and their alleged failure to reproduce; both are, in her opinion, detrimental to this generation of young Japanese people. The argument developed is by no means cohesive or logical and is mainly based on anecdotal evidence. Randomly selected sources from the natural sciences are used to back up arguments of biological determinism without following scientific methodology. Despite many contradictions, the argument is presented as the result of thorough research.

The Construction of the "Carnivore Woman"

Various illustrations throughout Sakuragi's book depict "carnivore women" as very feminine and attractive—they wear high heels, make up and have long hair. In addition, they are depicted as cruel, cold, and aggressive. Similar to the construction of the "herbivore men," several types of carnivore women named after different wildcat species—such as "tiger type carnivore women" (*toragata nikushokukei joshi* トラ型肉食系女子) (Sakuragi 2009: 71)—are presented. However, several characteristics are attributed to all "carnivore women" in this publication. This includes the active and continued pursuit of sexual or romantic partners as well as striving for positions of power within a heterosexual relationship and in society in general. According to Sakuragi, "carnivore women" see other women as rivals and therefore have very few

[11] Connell defines this metaphor in the biological determinist discourse as follows: "The body 'functions' and 'operates'. Researchers discover biological 'mechanisms' in behaviour. Brains are 'hardwired' to produce masculinity; men are genetically 'programmed' for dominance; aggression is in our 'biogram'. Both academic and journalistic texts are rich in these metaphors." (Connell 2005: 1193).

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female friends (ibid: 89). For example, "leopard type carnivore women" (*hyōgata nikushokukei joshi* ヒョウ型肉食系女子) are depicted as viewing women who have not found a marriage partner as "losers" (*make inu* 負け犬) (ibid: 69). The author thus presents "carnivore women" as competition oriented rather than team players who would exhibit female solidarity.

"Carnivore women" are described as being open about their sexuality; therefore, they are able to speak about their sexual needs such as masturbation or oral sex with a partner (ibid: 87-88). Because they like to play an active part in sexual intercourse, they are said to prefer the cowgirl position (ibid: 92). Since they do not care about dressing appropriately for their age, "carnivore women" are said to appear ageless and confident, which is why many men are attracted to them (ibid: 90). These women allegedly view men as generally inferior and weak, and enjoy the leading role in a sexual encounter or relationship in order to feel superior and in control (ibid: 92). The author claims a "carnivore woman" will leave a man if he cannot fulfil her wishes in bed (ibid: 94). Sakuragi sees "carnivore women's" desire for sexual satisfaction as especially problematic when they are in a relationship with "herbivore men" because of the latter's alleged "pathological sexual aversion" (*seikenobyō* 性嫌悪症) (ibid: 94). The aforementioned anecdote of the "The Man Who Cried Because of Reverse Rape" (ibid: 23) is an example of this construction of the "carnivore woman" as a sexual predator. Female sexual empowerment and sex-positivity are misrepresented as the wish to control men and as an indication of an underlying hatred of the male gender.

On the one hand, the development of the "carnivore" femininity is attributed to events in women's personal lives on an individual level. "Carnivore women" are portrayed as having a "Cinderella-complex" which leads to a never-ending search for the "prince on the white steed" and unrealistic expectations in romantic relationships (ibid: 96). Troubled father-daughter relationships allegedly lead "carnivore women" to expect men to act like their fathers (ibid: 166) who, in turn, represent hegemonic masculinity. Sakuragi (ibid: 199; 174) infers that the "herbivore men" cannot fulfil these expectations and thereby trigger women's continued "hunt" for partners and promiscuous behaviour:

> Today's girls think of men as 'useless', 'weak', and 'helpless' and they don't like the herbivore type etc. [But] because the total number of herbivore men is so high, [women's] options in their search for partners […] end up mostly being herbivore men (Sakuragi 2009: 174).

The author also suggests that women want men to be more aggressive or "carnivorous" in their courtship (199); "women have the wish to be assaulted," Sakuragi claims (ibid: 199). By approving of male sexual aggression and shaming sexually empowered women, the author supports the hegemonic masculinity discourses and the asymmetrical power relations they promote.

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On the other hand, in trying to find a reason for the changes in gender performance, the author describes the development of women's "carnivorous" behaviour in (sexual) relationships by referring to different femininities that are tied to societal phenomena from the 1980s to 2009. The appearance of *enjo kōsai* 援助交際, the practice of men paying high school girls or young women for their company, in the 1990s[12], is erroneously depicted as a major point of change in how females in Japan express their sexuality (ibid: 104). "Carnivore women," who were between twenty-five and thirty years-old in 2009 when Sakuragi's book was published, are said to have been *enkō gyaru* 援交ギャル (an abbreviation of *enjo kōsai*) when they were school girls (ibid: 112). Since Sakuragi claims that there is a general trend for women to become "carnivores," she presents *enjo kōsai* as a universal youth trend that was practiced by most girls, when in reality this phenomenon represents a "deviant career" outside of what is perceived as the norm (Nakano 2010). Additionally, the author overlooks the fact that *enjo kōsai* can range from dating without a sexual component to prostitution and is practiced not only by school girls but also by adult women (Caßing-Nakamura 2000: 212). The difference between young women exploring their sexuality and the prostitution of minors is not discussed. Sakuragi claims that because of this practice, women have become used to exploiting men for their personal and financial gain and perceiving them as "useless beings" (*dame na sonzai* ダメな存在) (Sakuragi 2009: 112). However, the author eventually blames "herbivore men" for the emergence of the practice of *enjo kōsai*, because of their assumed inability to take on the 'active' part in courtship (ibid: 113). The argument that women had to resort to paid dating because of men's disinterest in sexuality also shows how femininity and masculinity are wrongly perceived as two opposite poles in a clear-cut gender binary.

In summary, the development of "carnivore" femininity in this publication is attributed to events in women's personal lives that allegedly lead to expectations of hegemonic male behaviour that "herbivore men" do not fulfil (ibid.: 166). At the same time, however, the "carnivore women" discourse is connected to societal discourses of "deviant gender performance" like that of the *enjo kōsai* discourse in the 1990s. Moreover, it is entangled with the mass media discourse on "herbivore men." Considering that Sakuragi claims to be a "carnivore woman" herself, the reader might expect her to show empathy for this type of woman and support women's empowerment. However, this is not the case: Sakuragi portrays the "carnivore women" as pitiful or

[12] Kinsella argues that the Japanese media reinforced the image of the deviant school girl who would do anything to obtain luxury goods in the 1990s (Kinsella 2002: 228). This discourse had its beginnings in the 1980s when young, professional Japanese single women who celebrated their new financial independence by buying luxury brands were labelled as "bad girls" (Reisel 2017: 24). Japanese girls came to be demonised as part of a tainted youth associated with materialism and prostitution, as well as fetishised through the male gaze in the mass media at the same time (Kinsella 2014; Reisel 2017).

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"pathetic beings" (*aware na sonzai* 哀れな存在) (ibid: 97) who have to keep "hunting" for men without ever being truly fulfilled.

Ideological Embeddedness: The Backlash against "Gender-Free"

As discussed in the previous section, the main narrative in this discursive fragment is based on ideas of biological determinism in which a 'natural' masculinity and femininity—occupying opposite poles in the gender binary—are presumed. 'Natural' masculinity in this publication is further characterised by self-confidence, dominance, and sexual virility. The hegemonic masculinity, which is defined by economic power and disposable income, is supported by these notions of 'natural' masculine behaviour. By claiming that "herbivore men" are a deviant, unnatural, or diseased form of masculinity, Sakuragi positions herself within a line of discourse that aims to obliterate subversive masculinities and strengthen the current hegemony. Japanese mass media discourse that blamed the "herbivore men" for sinking birth rates (Schad-Seifert 2016) is woven into Sakuragi's argumentative strategy.

The publication can also be linked to the backlash against the "gender-free" movement in Japan. The expression "gender-free" (*jendā furī* ジェンダーフリー) was originally used in a brochure for teachers by the Tokyo Women's Foundation in 1995 (Yamaguchi 2014: 546). It aimed to combat stereotypical notions of gender on an educational level that lead to disadvantages for women in society (ibid). The Tokyo Women's Foundation defined the term as "freedom from compulsory gender roles" and promoted it in the hope of igniting a movement (Yamaguchi 2009: 547). The term was then adopted by parts of the Japanese feminist movement and interpreted as a more contemporary version of the collocation *danjo byōdō* 男女平等 (the equality of men and women), carrying the inherent meaning of men and women being "different but equal" (Yamaguchi 2014: 555). In the course of introducing the concept to the feminist movement as well as politics, a controversial debate concerning the different interpretations and underlying ideology of "gender free" was catalysed (Yamaguchi 2014; Kano 2011). Kano considers the term "gender free"—which came to be used to call attention to the "fundamental instability of categories such as sex, gender, and sexuality" and included LGBT individuals in the societal dialogue—as a concept similar to the Anglo-American "queer" (Kano 2011: 55).

After the establishment of the Basic Law for a Gender-Equal Society (*Danjo kyōdō sankaku shakai kihonhō* 男女共同参画社会基本法) in 1999, the term "gender free" was harshly criticised and a countermovement developed (Suzuki 2011: 21; 95). The mainstreaming of feminism or "state feminism" was perceived as a "feminist invasion" by conservative forces in Japan (Yamaguchi 2014: 558). This led to a severe backlash in the early 2000s against feminist endeavours to fight societal inequality and against the concept of "gender free" (Kano 2011). Kano summarises the arguments of the backlash as follows:

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> The argument of the backlash advocates can be summarised as a kind of biological essentialism: their main claim is that there are natural biological differences between men and women, and that this would dictate different social roles for men and women. The claim is that the state feminist policy (DKS) of promoting the continued employment of women during the childbearing years destroys the 'traditional Japanese family' consisting of the male breadwinner and the full-time housewife. Ironically, such a 'traditional family' had become the norm in Japan only for about a decade, in the 1970s, during the period of high economic growth (Kano 2011: 53).

Involved in this backlash were the Japanese Society for History Textbook Reform (*Atarashii rekishi kyōkasho o tsukuru kai* 新しい歴史教科書をつくる会), religious organisations, conservative politicians and neo-nationalists (Kano 2011: 52). However, the backlash also seemed to have hit a nerve with young men in times when economic recession, demographic change, and the "neoliberal transformation" of Japan led to a feeling of uneasiness about their future within Japanese society (Kano 2011: 53). Even Japanese housewives were involved and active in the backlash against feminist ideas of gender equality (Suzuki 2011).

Looking back at the discursive construction of the reversion of 'natural' femininity and masculinity which is apparent in Sakuragi's book (2009), the similarities with the discourse of backlash against the "gender free" concept are undeniable, since biological determinism dominates both argumentations. "Herbivore men" are constructed as an unnatural form of masculinity because—as discussed in detail above—they are said to lack traits that are marked as "male." Besides using arguments similar to those found in the backlash discourse, Sakuragi also openly speaks out about "gender free:" "they call it 'gender free' but are not aware that there is a difference between men and women" (2009: 82).

In summary, Sakuragi's *Lessons in Love for Carnivore Women: How Do They Devour the Herbivore Men?* was found to be discursively linked to the mass media discourse about "herbivore men" as well as the backlash against the "gender free" concept in the early 2000s. The latter used similar argumentative strategies to Sakuragi in the attempt to render feminist policy for gender equality ineffectual. Therefore, this publication can be seen as part of a sub-discourse within the general discourse on "herbivore masculinity" that works to prevent the legitimation of non-conforming heterosexual masculinities like that of the "herbivore man."

Conclusion

In 2009, the majority of love advice books published in Japan affirmed the masculinity of the "herbivore man" and therefore contributed to the legitimisation of alternative discourses of masculinity. However, the part of the discourse that rejected "herbivore men" was found to perpetuate the discourse of gender backlash against this masculinity in the mass media. Sakuragi Piroko's book *Lessons in Love for Carnivore Women:*

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How Do They Devour the Herbivore Men? (2009) served as an example for this line of discourse in the present study. Argumentative strategies of this discoursive position were found to be supportive of hegemonic masculinity and based on ideas of biological determinism. A 'natural' masculinity that constitutes men as biologically driven to be active, assertive, or even aggressive in their pursuit of sexual partners, is constructed in contrast to the "herbivore masculinity". Characterised by sexual passivity and non-aggressiveness, the "herbivore men" are depicted as an abnormality of nature. These men are further blamed for the development of "carnivore women," sexually active career women who are shamed for their "masculine" or aggressive pursuit of sexual partners. Female sexual empowerment is falsely portrayed as the problematic outcome of the pluralization of Japanese masculinities during the lost two decades. Similarly, the feminist concept of "gender-free" was disparaged and the value of a society with greater gender variety was disacknowledged in a phase of backlash against state feminism that characterised the 2000s.

The correlation of the argumentative strategies of both backlash discourses shows that biological determinism is perpetuated by Japanese conservatives in order to maintain the gender hegemony that defines men as sexually aggressive or even predatory, and women as passive "receivers" of sexuality without agency. This anti-feminist discourse reproduces asymmetrical heteronormative power structures in contemporary Japanese society and thus contradicts the establishment of equality of all genders and sexualities.

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GLOSSARY

Asashi Shinbun	朝日新聞	A large Japanese daily newspaper company
Atarashii rekishi kyōkasho o tsukuru kai	新しい歴史教科書をつくる会	Japanese Society for History Textbook Reform—a conservative Japanese organisation
aware na sonzai	哀れな存在	“Pathetic being,” a derogatory term
baka shōjiki	バカ正直	stupidly honest, too honest
bentō danshi	弁当男子	“bentō man”—a man who cooks and prepares his own lunchbox
chinko to manko no gyakuten genshō	チンコとマンコの逆転現象	“the phenomenon of reversion of dick and pussy,” a crude description of changing gender ideals in Japan by love advice book author Sakuragi Piroko (2009)
daikokubashira	大黒柱・大極柱	“supporting pillar of the house” —a metaphor for the male breadwinner of the family
dame na sonzai	ダメな存在	“useless being,” a derogatory term
danjō byōdō	男女平等	equality of men and women
Danjo kyōdō sankaku shakai kihonhō	男女共同参画社会基本法	This term was officially translated as Basic Law for a Gender-Equal Society but literally means “basic law for

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		the equal participation of men and women in society."
danseirashisa	男性らしさ	(stereotypical) masculinity
dorei	奴隷	"slave," used in the figurative as well as literal meaning of the term
enjo kōsai	援助交際	the practice of dating for money or presents—often used synonymously with school girl prostitution
enkō gyaru	援交ギャル	short for *enjo kōsai* girl—a female that engages in *enjo kōsai*
Fukasawa Maki	深澤真紀	Fukasawa Maki is the columnist who coined the term "herbivore man" (see *sōshoku danshi/ sōshokukei danshi*)
furītā	フリーター	freeter, non-permanent contract workers
gisei	犠牲	victim
gōkon	合コン	a communal meeting or party which is often attended to meet potential romantic or sexual partners
gyaku nan machi	逆ナン待ち	"waiting to be reversely picked up," a crude term used by love advice author Sakuragi Piroko (2009) to describe men's 'passive' behavior
gyaku nanpa	逆ナンパ	"reversed picking up," a crude term used by the love advice author Sakuragi Piroko (2009) to describe women's assertive behaviour
gyaku reipu	逆レイプ	"reverse rape," a crude term used by Sakuragi Piroko (2009) to describe a woman raping a man
Gyaku reipu de gōkyū shita otoko	逆レイプで号泣した男	"The Man Who Cried Because of Reverse Rape," an anecdote authored by Sakuragi Piroko (2009)
hyogata nikushokukei joshi	ヒョウ型肉食系女子	"leopard type carnivore women," a subcategory of the "carnivore woman"
ikigai	生きがい	something that gives life meaning
Ikuji kyūgyō hō	育児休業法	Childcare Leave Law (1992)

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ikumen	イクメン・育メン	"handsome dad," the term is a composition of the *kanji* for *iku* (to raise a child) and the *katakana* letters *men* for the English word "man." It thus sounds similar to *ikemen,* handsome man.
jendā furī	ジェンダーフリー	"gender free," a controversial term that was used in a pamphlet by the Tokyo Women's Foundation in an attempt to establish educational structures without gender bias
jibunrashisa	自分らしさ	"being oneself," a term that was coined by the Japanese sociologist Itō Kimio and describes an individual gender identity not confined by stereotypical masculinity
jikokeihatsusho	自己啓発書	self-help book or self-improvement book
Jiyū Kokuminsha	自由国民社	A Japanese publishing company
judōteki	受動的	being passive
kigyō senshi	企業戦士	"corporate warrior"—nickname for white collar employees in the period of high economic growth
make inu	負け犬	"loser," a derogatory term
manyuaru	マンユアル	handbook
Morioka Masahiro	森岡正博	Japanese academic and author of self-help and love advice books
moteraitā	モテライター	popular writer or writer who helps other people to become popular
Nikkei Bijinesu Onrain	日経ビジネスオンライン	"Nikkei Business Online," the online version of the Japanese paper *Nikkei Business*
nikushokukei danshi	肉食系男子	"carnivore type man," a type of man who is said to be assertive or aggressive in their approach to finding romantic or sexual partners
nikushokukei joshi	肉食系女子	"carnivore type woman," a type of woman that is said to be assertive in their approach to finding romantic or sexual partners

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Nikushokukei joshi no renaigaku: kanojo tachi wa ika ni sōshokukei danshi o kuimakuru no ka	肉食系女子の恋愛学:彼女たちはいかに草食系男子を食いまくるのか	*Lessons in Love for Carnivore Women: How Do They Devour the Herbivore Men?* A love advice book by Sakuragi Piroko (2009)
Non-no	ノンノ	a popular Japanese women's magazine about fashion and lifestyle
okama	御釜・御竈	an insulting term for men who are assumed to be or shamed for being gay or not conforming to hegemonic masculinity, comparable to the English slur "faggot" or "homo"
Okuda Hiromi	奥田弘美	Japanese author of self-help books
o-warai raitā	お笑いライター	comedy writer
rīdā / rīdō	リーダー・リードー	leader / to lead in a romantic or sexual encounter
Saigo no koi wa sōshokukei danshi ga motte kuru	最後の恋は草食系男子が持ってくる	*Herbivore Men Will Bring Your Last Love*—love advice book by Morioka Masahiro (2009)
Sakuragi Piroko	桜木 ピロコ	A Japanese author of love and relationship advice books
sararīman	サラリーマン	"salaryman," a Japanese white-collar employee in the private sector
seiken'obyō	性嫌悪症	pathological sexual aversion
sengyō shufu	専業主婦	full-time housewife
shōkyokuteki	消極的	passive or non-assertive
sōshoku danshi/ sōshokukei danshi	草食男子・草食系男子	"herbivore man" or "herbivore type man," a type of man that is said to be passive in his approach to finding romantic or sexual partners
Sōshokukei bijinesuman no tame no sutoresufurī shigotojutsu	草食系ビジネスマンのためのストレスフリー仕事術	*Stress Free Life Hacks for Herbivorous Businessmen*—self-help book by Okuda Hiromi (2009)
Sōshoku danshi sedai: Heisei danshi zukan	草食男子世代—平成男子図鑑	*Generation of Herbivore Men: An Illustrated Encyclopaedia of Men in the Heisei Era*—book by Fukasawa Maki (2009)
Sōshokukei danshi no toriatsukai setsumeisho: torisetsu	草食系男子の取扱説明書:トリセツ	*The User Manual for Herbivore Men*—a love advice book by Ushikubo Megumi (2009)

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suītsu danshi	スイーツ男子	"sweets men" or "sweet men," men who prefer sweet drinks and desserts instead of spicy food and beer
Terebi Tōkyō	テレビ東京	"TV Tōkyō," a private Japanese television broadcaster
toragata nikushokukei joshi	トラ型肉食系女子	"tiger type carnivore woman" —a subcategory of the "carnivore woman," see *nikushokukei joshi*
ūmanribu / ribu	ウーマンリブ・リブ	"women's lib," the women's liberation movement
Ushikubo Megumi	牛窪恵	Japanese author who published several books about Japanese men's changing behavior
yariman	ヤリマン	an insulting term for women who are assumed to be or shamed for being sexually active, comparable to the English slur "slut"
Yūkan shingo ryūkōgo taishō	ユーキャン新語流行語大賞	the U-can prize for the ten trend words of the year awarded by the Japanese publishing company Jiyū Kokuminsha

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